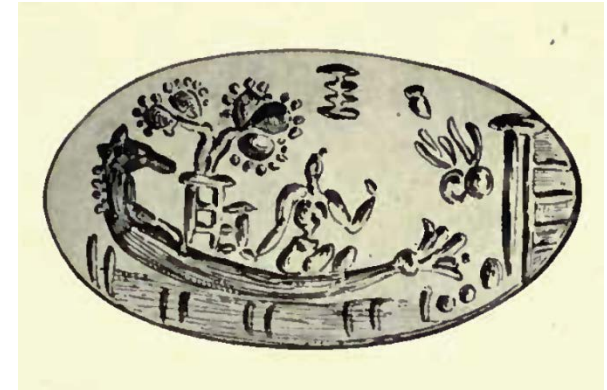
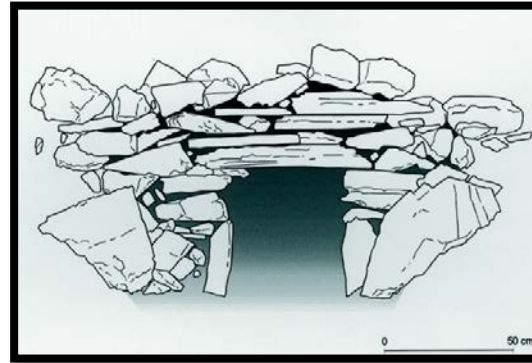




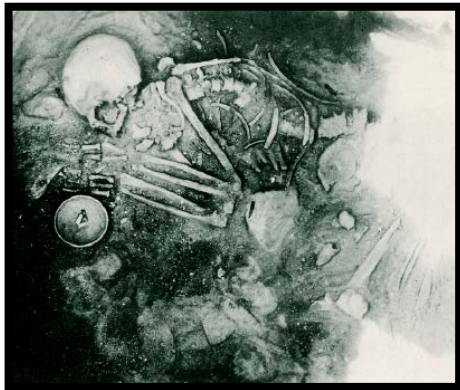
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The 'never-ending' journey? Death and the Sea in Bronze Age Greece

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Introduction

- Focus on specific performative actions
 - Location
 - Grave type
 - Grave goods and funeral
- Water = Sea
- Diachronic perspective
- ‘Seascape’ includes practices related to water
 - Fishing
 - Sailing
 - Representation





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Limitations and Previous Research



- Bronze Age Greece – 3300-1100 BCE.
- Role of the sea in eschatological belief in Late Bronze Age (1800-1100 BCE) (Marinatos 1993; Gallou 2002)
- Deployment of maritime connection in mortuary arena, Early Cyclades (Broodbank 2000) (3300-2300 BCE)
- Seascape a resource for manipulation in mortuary rites in Early Minoan Crete (Vavouranakis 2011) (3300-2300 BCE)



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CEMETERY LOCATION

1. Agia Photia Crete (EM I-II (3000-2500 BCE)



- Cycladic islanders?
Similarities in tomb type with **Agrilia** on Ano Koufonisi in Cyclades.
Cycladic grave goods in many tombs
Cemetery on cliffs overlooking the sea to the north
- Sea integral to identity in death?
- Orientation to location of origin
- Mnemonic device?

2. Voidhokilia (MH III/LH I, 1800-1600 BCE)

- Important tholos tomb
- Placed above one side of the entrance into bay
- Views inside and outside bay



2. Voidhokilia (MH III/LH I, 1800-1600 BCE)

- Positioning significant for mortuary rites?
- Assertion of authority over the seascape?
- Visibility and inscription of the landscape



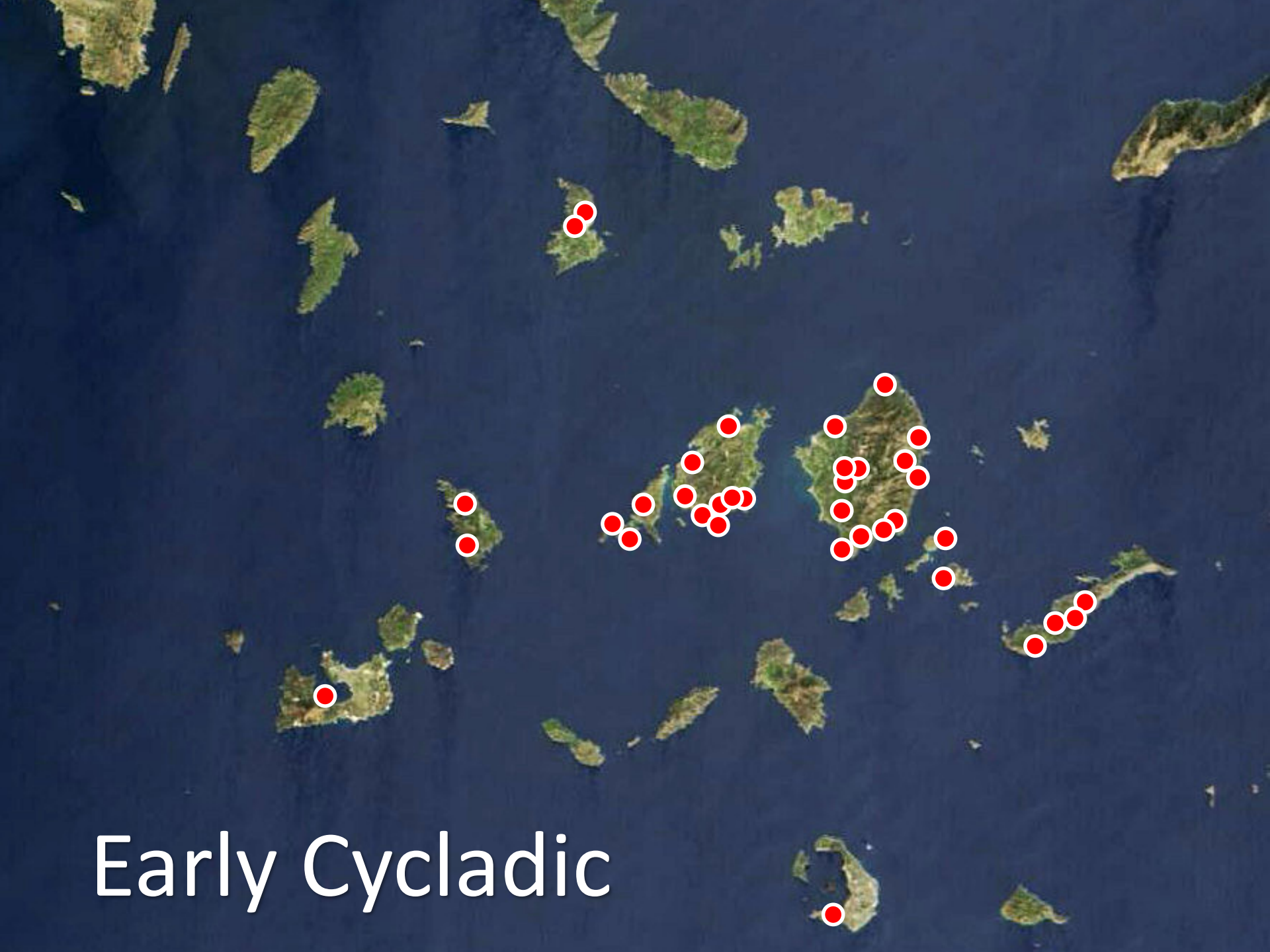


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GRAVE TYPE

1. EB III-MB *lacuna*? (2200-1600 BCE)

- Remarkable *lacuna* of cemeteries from EB III-MB and beyond.
- In the EBA, cemeteries are common, with above 30 being known.
- EC Cycladic communities were small
- MC Cycladic communities were larger (most around or over 1 hectare)
- Scant evidence for burial in the MC period.



Early Cycladic



Middle Cycladic



Early Cycladic cemeteries

	NAME	ISLAND	PHASE	INTERNEMENTS
1	Akrotiri	Naxos	EC I	c.23
2	Kampos	Naxos	EC I	c. 90 graves
3	Lakkoudhes	Naxos	EC I	26
4	Lakkoudhes A	Naxos	EC I	6
5	Rhodhinadhes	Naxos	EC I	c.4
6	Agioi Anargyroi	Naxos	EC I-IIA	c.44
7	Karvounolakkoi	Naxos	EC I-IIA	82 graves
8	Phyrroyes	Naxos	EC I-IIA	120 graves
9	Tsikniades	Naxos	EC I-IIB	122 graves
10	Aphentika	Naxos	EC IIA	170 graves
11	Avdheli	Naxos	EC IIA	Robbed. c.3
12	Dhokathismata	Amorgos	EC IIA	c.20 graves
13	Kapros	Amorgos	EC IIA	c.20 graves
14	Kapsala	Amorgos	EC IIA	11 tombs
15	Stavros	Amorgos	EC IIA	6 graves
16	Agios Loukas	Syros	EC IIA-III	94 graves
17	Chalandriani	Syros	EC IIA-B	+1000
18	Avyssos	Paros	EC I	c.2
19	Glypha	Paros	EC I	c.4
20	Mnemia	Paros	EC I	c.1
21	Panagia	Paros	EC I?	?
22	Plastiras	Paros	EC I	? Robbed c. 13
23	Pyrgos	Paros	EC I	58 graves
24	Kamari	Paros	EBA	c.1
25	Galana Gremna	Paros	EBA	28 graves
26	Krassadhes	Antiparos	EC I	50 graves
27	Agrilia	Ano Kouphonisi	EC I-II	72 graves
28	Zoumaria	Despotikon	EC I	34 graves
29	Livadhi	Despotikon	EC I-IIA	c.27
30	Akrotiraki	Siphnos	EC I	c.11
31	Vathi	Siphnos	EC I	c.2
32	Rivari	Melos	EC IIB-III	c. 5 graves

- 1167 internments + 982 tombs
- **Total:**
- **2149-3131** internments for 1000 years.
- = **2.15-3.13** per year for the whole Cyclades

+1000



Middle Cycladic Cemeteries

	NAME	ISLAND	PHASE	INTERMENTS
1	Agios Ioannis	Thera	ECIII/MC early	? c.5
2	Ailas	Naxos	MC late	c.4
3	Ayia Irini	Kea	MC late	25
4	Akrotiri	Thera	MC	Intra-mural. c. 1?
5	Phylakopi	Melos	ECIII/MC?	Intra-mural. c. 4?
6	Paroikia	Paros	ECIII/MC?	Intra-mural. c. 4?
7	Skarkos	Ios	MC late	?

- Total: **35-40** individuals for a period of c.600 years.
- **0.058-0.066** per year for the whole Cyclades

?

? Where **are** they buried? ?

?



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Sea-burial?

- Perhaps we haven't found them yet?
- Unlikely, we have found many EC cemeteries, but no MC cemeteries. Extensive survey and exploration of landscape since 1800's
- **Sea burial?**
- Settlements of MC were coastal. Impossible to prove or disprove sea burial but a possibility which ought to be considered.





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2. Minoan Larnakes

- Larnakes emerge in MBA (c.1900 BCE) and are a feature of LBA (1600-1100 BCE)
- Representation of marine themes
- Mavrospilia – Argonauts, MM III

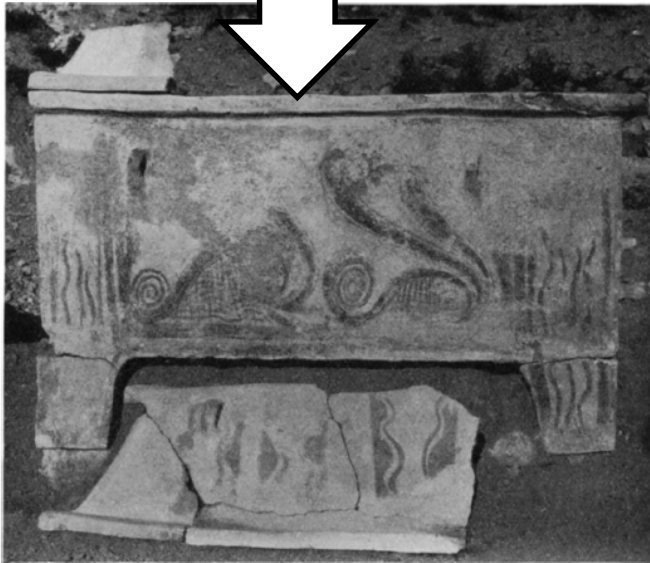


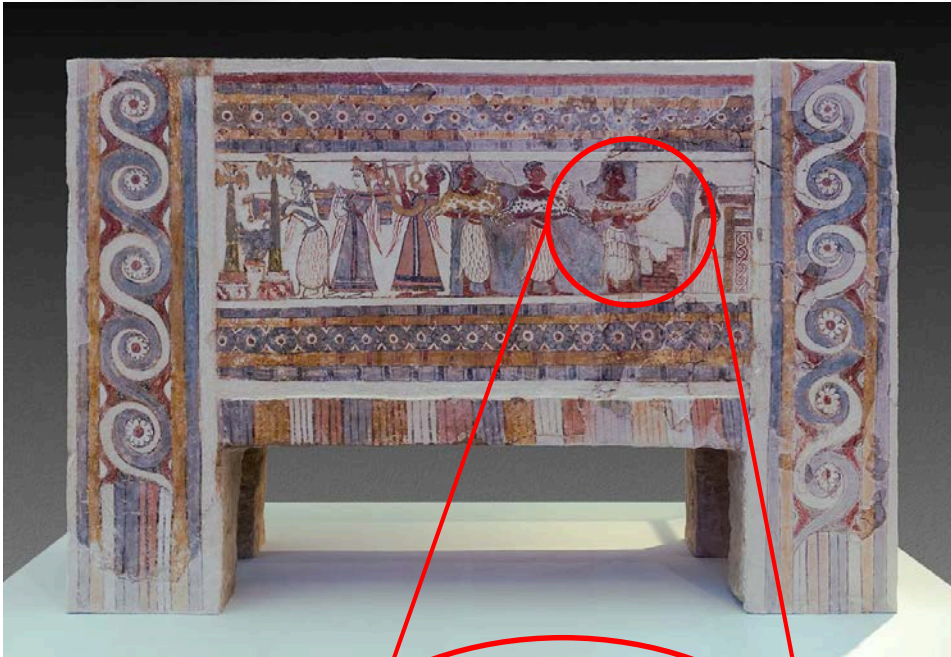
FIG. 26.—PAINTED LARNAX AND LID, TOMB XI. 1.





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2. Minoan Larnakes



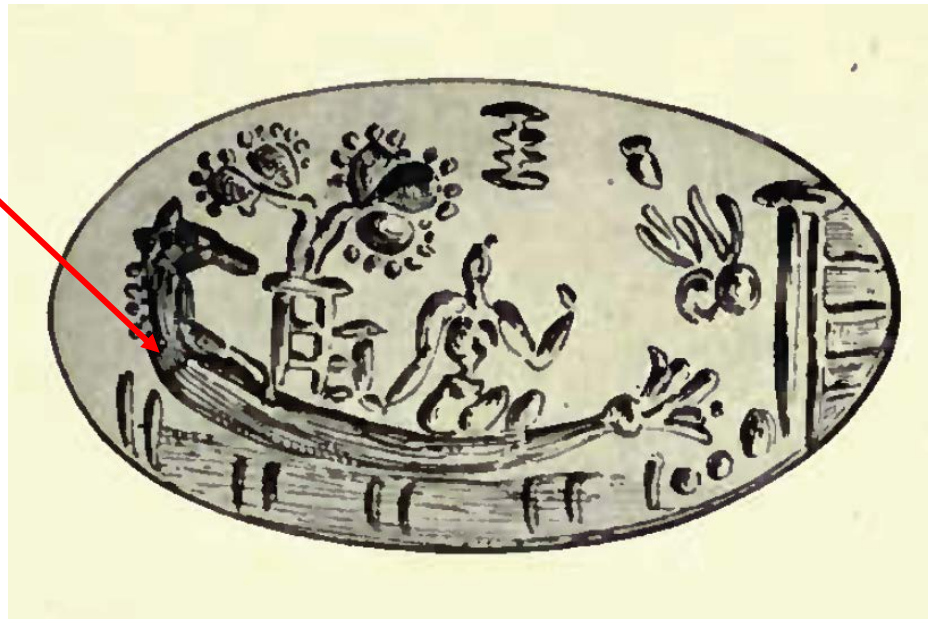
- Agia Triadha – LM III (c.1400 BCE)
- Procession on both sides
- Boat offering
- Real boat or boat model?
- Is it even a boat?



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Larnax: Death and the Sea

- Mix of marine motifs in a funerary context
- Depiction of deities close to water in other arenas
- Is the boat significant on a metaphorical journey across water to the afterworld?





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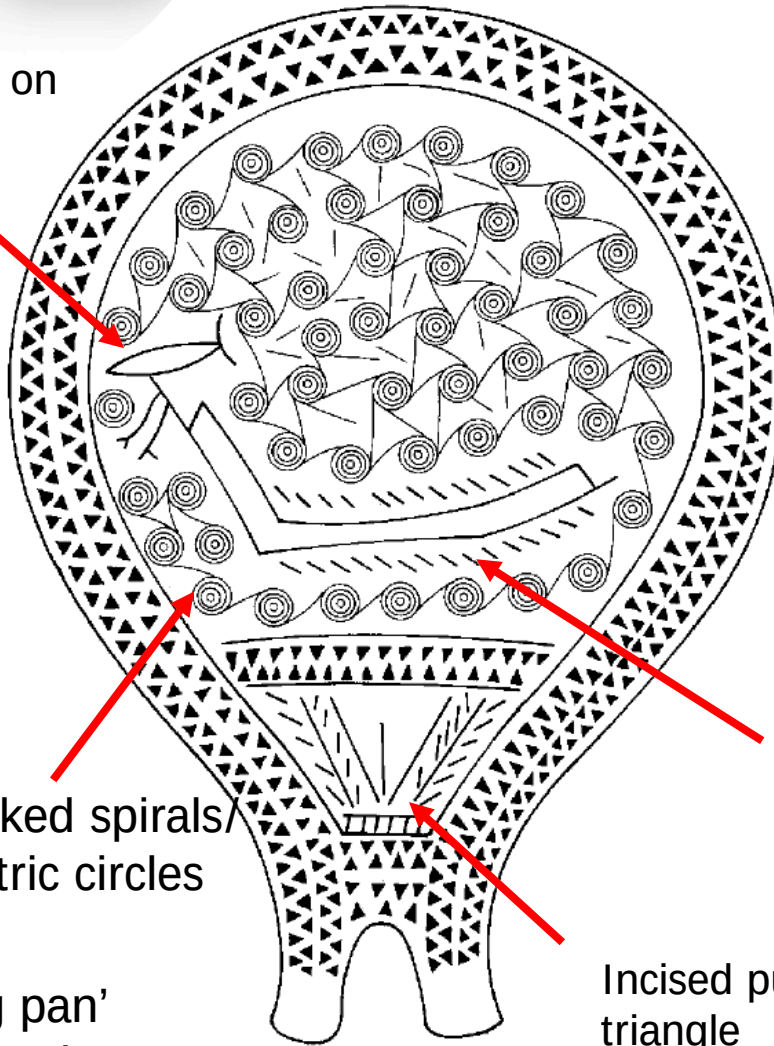
GRAVE DEPOSITION AND PERFORMANCE



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1. “Frying pans” EC II (2900-2500 BCE)

Fish
‘totem’ on
prow?

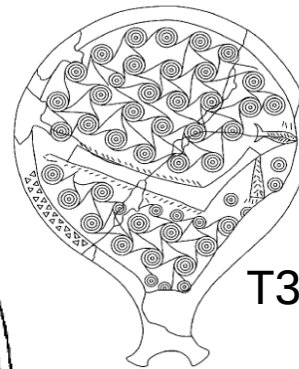


Interlocked spirals/
Concentric circles

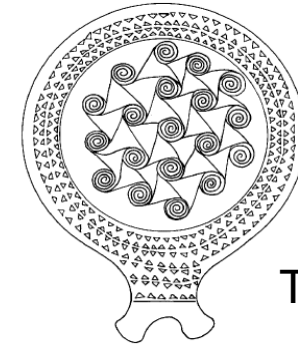
‘Frying pan’
from tomb 174

Boat
with
oars

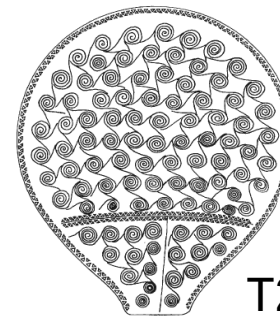
Incised pubic
triangle



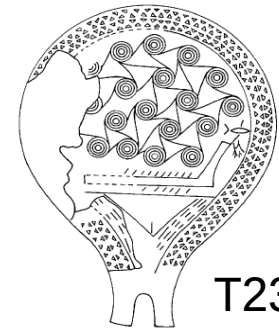
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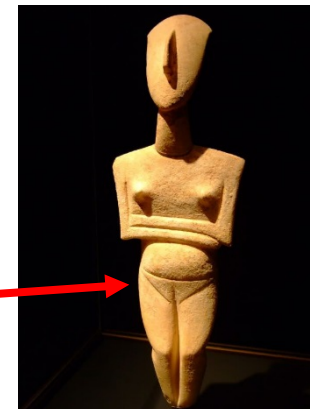
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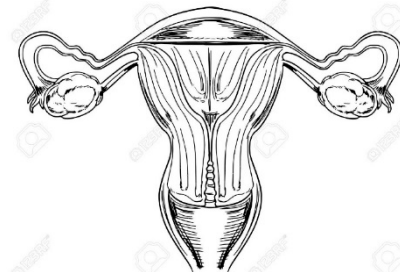
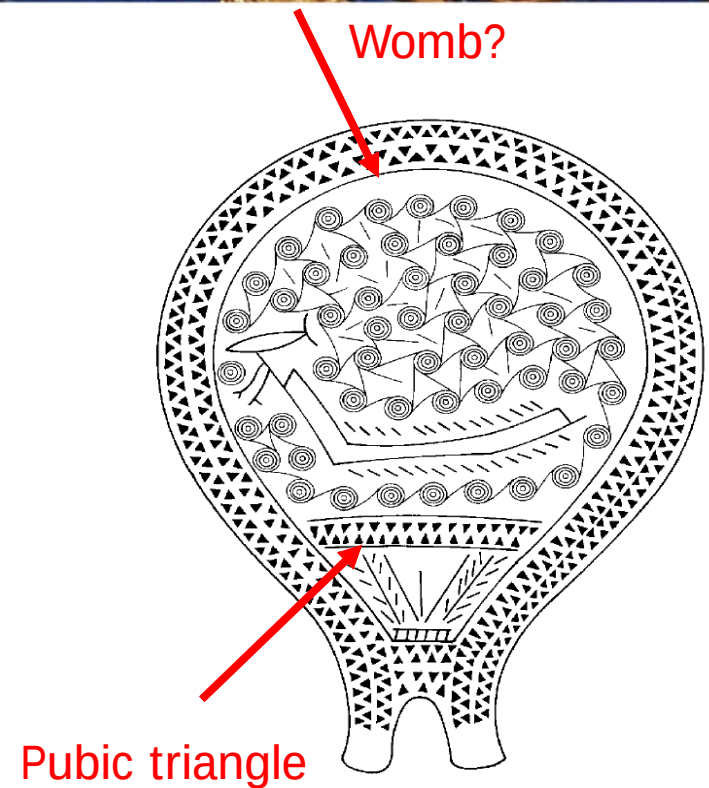
T239





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- Ritual objects
- Womb-like? Frying pan connected to fertility? (Goodison 1989)
- Cycladic figurines are found in tombs, often in differing stages of pregnancy
- Cosmologically significant in biological reproduction?
- Sea depicted *inside* the womb – reference to the waters breaking?



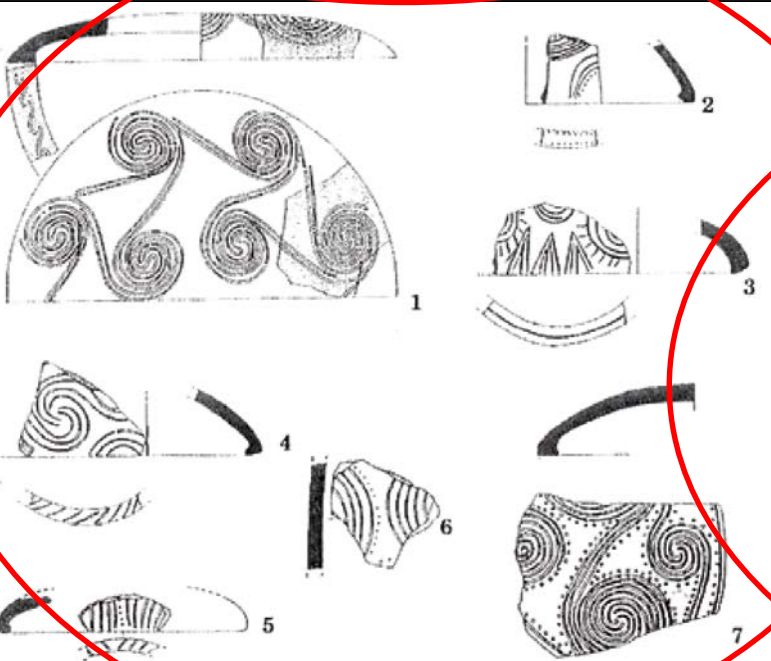
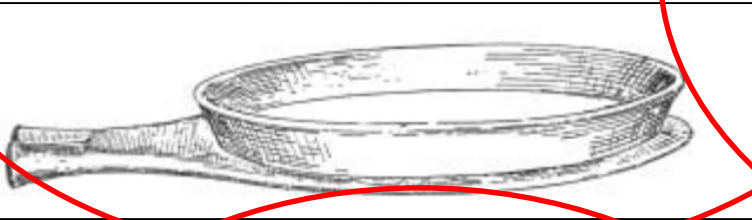
- Experimental archaeology shows they would function quite well as mirrors with 'darkened' olive oil **Papathanassoglou and Georgouli, 2009**



- Used for the production of salt cakes? **Cassen et al 2012; Doumas 1993**



- Drum?
- Incense burner?
- Libations?
- Astrolabe?



'Bratislava lids' from Eastern Europe



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- Is death a watery journey?
- We have seen that sea was potentially significant in fertility.
- Could the mixing of seascape, fertility and mortuary practices be linked to the sea as a medium for rebirth?

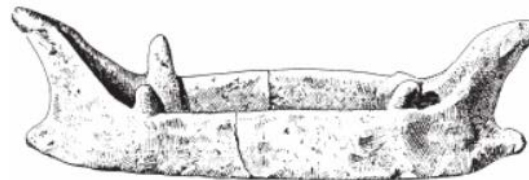
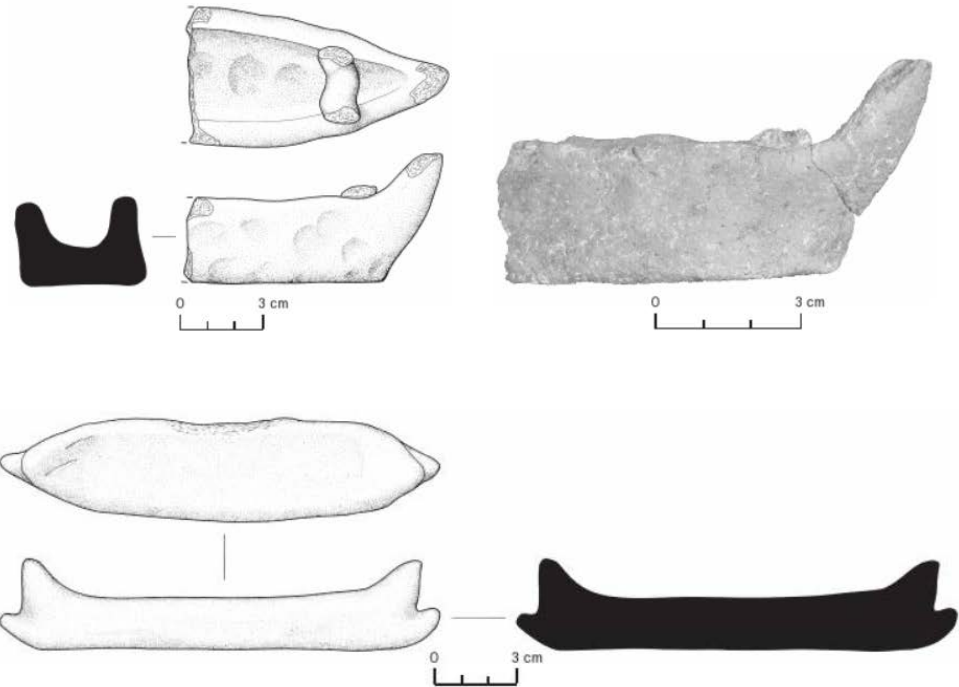




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2A. Model Boats

- Terracotta boat models found in some tombs across various periods
- **Mochlos** on Crete – boats associated with some tombs MM-LM (2000-1400 BCE)
- **Tanagra** and **Megalo Kastelli** – LH II-III
- Symbolising a journey to the underworld?
- Not a common grave offering



a



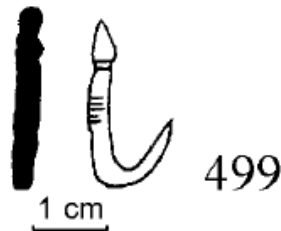
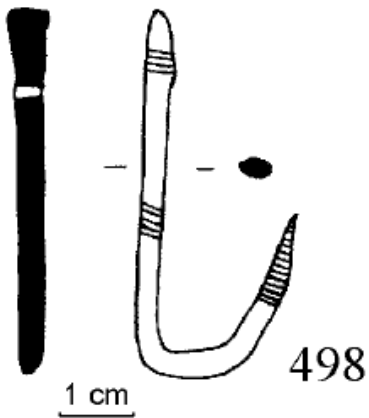
b



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2B. Fish hooks

Tomb 453



- Rare offering but known
- **Chalandriani** on **Syros**— Tomb 453.
- EC II (2900-2500 BCE)
- Fish hooks attached with line – only grave offering in tomb
- Connection to the sea in life?



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2C. Representation

- Jewellery or pottery bearing marine representation.
- E.g Grave Circle A in the early Mycenaean period (1800-1600 BCE)
- Octopi, squids, dolphins on some material culture





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- Various species

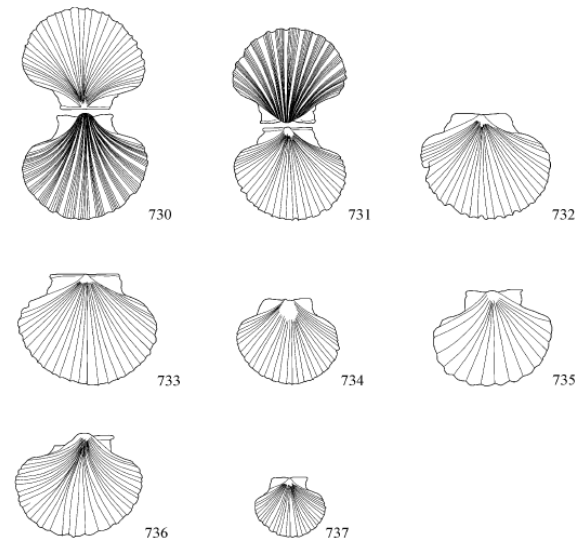
Early Bronze Age (c. 3300 – 2200 BCE)

- Shell necklaces in Tomb 343 at Chalandriani

Late Bronze Age (c. 1600 – 1100 BCE)

- Sea shells at Peristeria tholos tomb in Messenia
- Intentional offerings?
- Detritus from funerary meals?
- Not always in tombs beside the coast
- Sea-shell necklaces strong evidence for deployment of sea-related objects in tombs

2D. Seashells





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3. Pebbles, Sand and Sea Water.

- Akrotiri on Thera – MC (1900-1600 BCE)
- Large stone pithos, c. 1.3 m high
- Stone vessel containing pebbles
- All in *Cenotaph sq.* An E (2900-2500 BCE) ceme with a 'cairn' of MC late date – later veneration?
- Accumulation of beach gravel only noted in this space.





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3. Pebbles, Sand and Sea Water.

Early Bronze Age

- Agioi Anargyroi on Naxos – pebbles laid on top of EC graves
- Rivari on Melos – beach gravel spread across the area of the deposit pits.





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3. Pebbles, Sand and Sea Water.

Middle – Late Bronze Age

- **Asine, Argolid** – grave with pebble floor and sand and pebbles lain over bodies of dead
- Pebbles used in grave circles. **Mycenae** is c. 15km from the coast.
- **Voidhokilia, Messenia** – sea pebbles in the floor of the Tholos
- **Vafio, Laconia** – sea pebble floor on the entranceway

3. Pebbles, Sand and Sea Water.

- Stone pithos used for sea-water?
- Not associated with a tomb
- Centrally placed
- Purification rituals and miasma? (Doumas 2008)
- Or symbolic of the journey to the afterlife?
- Close proximity to sea
- Doumas suggests outer surface of tombs and cemetery were sealed with sand and pebbles to prevent miasma





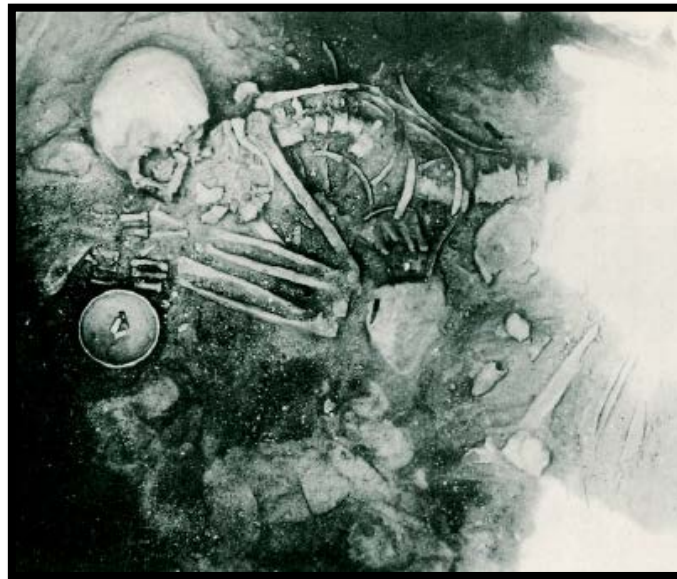
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? ? ?

COULD THE MARBLE VESSELS, PYXIDES AND FRYING PANS BE CONTAINERS FOR SEA-WATER?

?

?





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Some thoughts...

- Aegean mortuary practices not centred on relationship between sea and death across area and time span
- **BUT** in specific places and times this relationship could be observable.
- Sea as a potentially significant space in eschatological belief
- Aegean an archipelago region
- Sea a contradictory space
- Rejection of isomorphic view of mortuary practices
- Specific choices to incorporate links to the sea
- For every depiction of a *fish* or *boat* we could just as easily have a **horse** or **chariot**
- Choice that marine objects are befitting of mortuary practices



Voyage to the afterworld?

- Underlying theme of whether there was a voyage overseas to the “afterworld” in Aegean eschatology (Nilsson 1968, 622-30; Grumbach 1968, 24-5)
- Originated in Crete and extrapolated to Cyclades (Goodison 1989) and Mycenaean Greece (Gallou 2002)
- Sacrifice or metaphorical offerings to ensure divine protection on journey (Watrous 1991, 305)
- Heavily influenced by contemporary Egyptian belief
- Voyage to the afterworld supported by later Greek textual evidence – ‘Islands of the blessed’ (Vermuele 1979, 229; Hesiod Works and Days 170f)

Problems with 'the voyage'

- Homer (c. 750 BCE):
- closest in time to the Bronze Age, little mention of a voyage to the underworld
- Textual evidence from Archaic (c. 700-500 BCE) and Classical (500-323 BCE):
- Much too late!
- Egyptian influence in material culture on Crete:
- Is it probable that **belief systems** were adopted wholesale?
- Alternate idea: octopi and argonauts were significant in mortuary sphere due to **regenerative** properties (Saunders 2008):
- Does not account for **boats, fish and artefacts**





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Yet more thoughts...

- Incorporation of the sea into localised belief systems in varying ways
- Local **stories**, local **choices**
- **No overarching theme** or it would be more evident everywhere
- Link between regeneration, cleansing, rebirth and fertility in connection between the sea and death.
- Could the sea have been perceived as a place where the dead go and can return from?



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Thanks for your time!